

AT HOME
A tigress with her cub at the Tadoba National Park in Maharashtra

MAHARASHTRA/ WILDLIFE

SHIFTING STRIPES

By Dhaval Kulkarni

It may be India's national animal and a flagship species, but Maharashtra is confronted with a problem of plenty. A steady growth in the number of tigers in the state has increased their conflict with humans, and has prompted the state government to work on a plan to translocate these big cats to other states. It is also shifting tigers from forestscapes marked by over-abundance to other areas in Maharashtra that still have the capacity to absorb more tigers.

At one level, this speaks of a success story—the All India Tiger Estimation Report, 2018, put the number of these apex carnivores in the state at 312, nearly doubling from 169 in the 2010 tiger census. At present, those numbers are estimated to have risen to 352 adults; the figure may even touch 500 if sub-adults are accounted for. However, this population growth, which otherwise indicates a healthy habitat and good conservation practices, has come at a price. Most of these tigers are concentrated in just one eco-zone— specifically, the districts of Chandrapur and Gadchiroli in Vidarbha. For instance, of the population of 312 in 2018, over half—an unviably high 166—were in the Chandrapur district alone. At present, Chandrapur and Gadchiroli may account for 230 of the state's 352 tigers. This includes 86 in the Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve (TATR), which serves as a source population for the 117 tigers in the Chandrapur territorial circle and 27 tigers in the Gadchiroli territorial circle.

This rising tiger demographic has also meant a corresponding growth in human-animal conflict. From 2019 to 2022-end, a total of 122 people were killed in attacks by tigers in Chandrapur and 43 in Gadchiroli—measure that against the total of 193 for all Maharashtra. In 2022, 76 humans died in tiger attacks across the state—again, a clearly rising graph from 54 in 2021, 39 in 2020 and 24 in 2019.

"We are working on a policy which will enable us to translocate tigers to other states. States like Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh have shown interest in our tigers," says Sudhir Mungantiwar, state forest minister. Once finalised, the plan will be sent to the Union government and the National Tiger Conservation Authority for approval. Relocation of these tigers will help reduce tiger populations in areas with excess numbers and thus reduce man-animal conflict. It will also reintroduce tigers in areas which have a scanty base of these carnivores.

In September 2022, the Maharashtra forest department secured permissions from the Union ministry of environment, forest and climate change